

treatment, sitting with them while they wait for someone to come out of surgery, consulting with them in an area where they may need some assistance with business, investing, etc. Even exercising a little patience with someone you find challenging can be a huge gift in certain circumstances. Volunteering opportunities abound for this item.

5. Kiva.org

Kiva.org is only one of many options to help those on the other side of the world from you. For an initial modest donation, you can have an account that keeps on giving long-term.

6. Thoughtful purchases

By making careful choices about which items a person will truly need or love, you can make sure the gift does not go to waste. Don't buy a gift just for the sake of gifting.

7. Be there

Honestly. Just be there. During a major family crisis, if you've flown thousands of miles to be there and paid countless dollars in travel costs to offer support, should anybody give a damn if you have flowers in your hand? It's nice if you do, of course.

But if you can't, and they don't understand . . . maybe you need to rethink your relationship with that person or group of people.

8. Stick to your guns

Again, this is another item that may seem odd to include on a list of generosity ideas. However, I'm struck by something I heard Suze Orman say once on the *Oprah Winfrey Show*. By giving in when your conscience is telling you not to, what you are really sharing is the poverty cycle. Think about what funds you'll have available if you keep giving frivolous high-cost items and then a crisis comes up that you feel it's mandatory to write a check for. A funeral, the surgery of a child in the family, the winter coat for a niece or nephew whose parents might have hit a financial roadblock . . . you get the picture. Your friends will understand if you let them know you just can't afford to buy a nice gift for them.

9. Set a dollar amount for incidental gifts

This of course will be a personal decision based on where you are financially and what your goals are. But there are lots of ideas out there for affordable gift giving, whether you